

ESSENTIAL

Tourist Visa Master Guide

The complete walkthrough - the sponsor model, entry routes, and FAQs

VERIFY BEFORE YOU APPLY

Fees, forms, and processing times change without notice. This guide reflects publicly documented procedures as commonly published; treat every dollar figure, form number, and timeline here as a starting point, and confirm the current version on the official government site before you submit anything or pay any fee.

What the Tourist Visa is - and the system behind it

The UAE Tourist Visa covers most leisure and short business visits under 90 days combined across the standard visa lengths. It sits within UAE federal immigration law, administered primarily by the Federal Authority for Identity, Citizenship, Customs & Port Security (ICP). Dubai runs its own General Directorate of Residency and Foreigners Affairs (GDRFA Dubai), which issues visas for entry specifically via Dubai through a materially separate system from the federal one used by the other emirates - a genuinely UAE-specific structural point worth understanding if your entry point matters to your plans.

The process end to end

Step	What happens
1. Confirm your route	Check whether you're visa-exempt, eligible for visa-on-arrival, or need a pre-arranged e-visa, based on your nationality.
2. Choose a sponsor	An airline, hotel, licensed tour operator, or UAE resident applies on your behalf - individuals generally don't apply directly.
3. Arrange health insurance	Mandatory cover for your stay, arranged by you or bundled by your sponsor depending on the channel.
4. Sponsor submits the application	Through their own approved government-linked channel.
5. Decision	Often within a few working days; no interview; no stated reason if refused.
6. Receive your e-visa	A printed document, usually emailed as a PDF - not a passport sticker.

The 5-year multiple-entry tourist visa

Beyond the standard 30/60-day visas, the UAE offers a longer 5-year multiple-entry tourist visa to eligible nationalities who meet a separate, specifically published financial-means requirement (commonly framed around a minimum bank balance or income level). This is a different application track from the standard short visas and isn't covered in depth by this document set - check the current eligibility criteria directly if you're specifically interested in it.

Health insurance - a hard requirement

Like Schengen (though for different structural reasons), UAE tourist visas require proof of health insurance covering your stay - this isn't optional or merely advisable. Depending on your sponsor and channel, this may be arranged for you as part of the visa cost, or you may need to arrange and provide proof of it separately.

Frequently asked questions

Do I get a stamp or sticker in my passport?

No - the approved e-visa is a printed document (typically a PDF), not a vignette. On arrival, an immigration officer stamps your passport with your actual entry, but the pre-approval itself is a separate paper/digital document you should carry.

Can I extend my visa once in the UAE?

Extensions are possible in some circumstances but are handled separately from the initial application - check current options and fees with the relevant authority (ICP or GDRFA Dubai, depending on your entry point) if you think you'll need longer.

What if my application doesn't succeed?

See the Refusal & Reapplication Guide (Premium tier) - since there's typically no stated reason or formal appeal, the practical approach is different from most other countries.